



Using cvendian for Byte Order Conversion

Version 2026.1
2026-04-20

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PDF generated on 2026-04-20
InterSystems IRIS Version 2026.1
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Using cvendian for Byte Order Conversion

This page describes how to use **cvendian** to convert or report on the byte order of an InterSystems database. You can use this utility for migration between Big-endian and Little-endian platforms.

1 Introduction to cvendian

The **cvendian** utility converts (or reports on) the byte order of an InterSystems database. This utility is the file *install-dir\Bin\cvendian.exe*.

Important: You cannot use this utility on a mounted database.

Also, the utility does not work for backup and journal files. You must restore databases on a platform of the same endian, move the restored databases to the different endian platform, and then use **cvendian** to convert the databases.

The utility uses simple buffered I/O to read and write the target file. For best performance, ensure that operating system (OS) file-system caching is not disabled.

2 Conversion Process

You can run **cvendian** on either the system that has the files to be converted or the system that will be using the converted files.

For example, to convert a database from a Little-endian to a Big-endian system, you can perform the conversion on the Little-endian system and then transfer the database to the Big-endian system, or you can transfer the file first, and then convert it.

To convert a database, the process is:

1. Make a copy of your database files, because the utility replaces the source files with the converted files.
2. Run **cvendian** using the syntax described in the [Utility Syntax](#) section.
3. If the database file is encrypted, enter the encryption key and user/password when prompted. The utility does not provide command-line options for passing in these values.

3 Utility Syntax

With the **cvendian** utility, you can specify the desired byte order, or you can report the current byte order without conversion. Use the following syntax:

```
cvendian [-option] file
```

The *option* argument is one of the following:

- **-big** — convert the database to Big-endian

- `-little` — convert the database to Little-endian
- `-report` — report the byte order of the database

You can shorten the options to their initial letter. If this is a conversion request (*-big* or *-little*), and the database already has the specified byte order, the utility displays a warning message and stops processing.

If you do not provide the *option* argument, the utility converts the database from the existing byte order to the other byte order. It is recommended, however, that you use the *option* argument.

The *file* argument is the file to convert, and can include a complete pathname.

The utility performs the following actions:

- Auto-detects the byte order of the database
- Displays endian information and other information
- Performs the conversion
- Displays a message indicating success or failure

For example, suppose you are converting a database for use on AIX from Windows. This means you must convert from Little-endian to Big-endian. The output from running **cvendian** on the Windows system before moving the file to the AIX system looks similar to this:

```
C:\IrisSys\Bin>cvendian -big c:\temp\powerdb\iris.dat
This database is little-endian.
This database has a block size of 8192 bytes.
This database has 1 volume and 1 map.
The last block in the primary volume is 18176.
Original manager directory is c:\temp\powerdb\
No extension volumes.
Done converting c:\temp\powerdb\iris.dat to big-endian
C:\IrisSys\Bin>
```

You can now move the converted database file to the AIX system.

4 See Also

- Platform Endianness